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Beyond Tomorrow – A Starship for Cancer

ACT will build New Zealand's first purpose-built comprehensive cancer centre – a world-leading institution dedicated to saving lives and transforming cancer care.

Cancer is New Zealand's biggest killer. More than 30,000 New Zealanders are diagnosed each year, and by 2044 that number is expected to exceed 45,000. New Zealand records around 1,061 more cancer deaths every year than it would if we matched Australian cancer-specific mortality rates.

We should not accept being second-rate at treating a disease that touches almost every family.

Starship showed what can happen when New Zealand concentrates talent, technology, generosity, and national ambition around a single mission.

ACT will do the same for cancer.

We will support the establishment of a National Cancer Centre with two campuses – one in Auckland and one in Christchurch – bringing together world-class clinical care, complex surgery, radiation oncology, genomics, diagnostics, clinical trials, research, and some of the best cancer specialists in the world.

The Christchurch campus will provide a major centre for the South Island and lower North Island, representing around 40 percent of New Zealand's population. The remaining 60 percent in the North Island will be served from the Auckland centre.

Our ambition is not simply to build the best cancer facilities in New Zealand. It is to create a cancer institution capable of standing alongside the best in Melbourne, London, Toronto, and elsewhere around the world.

01 Build something extraordinary

Cancer care in New Zealand is currently dispersed across hospitals, research institutes, universities, charities, and private providers.

ACT will support an independent, not-for-profit National Cancer Centre Foundation to bring that expertise together.

The Centre will unite leading cancer researchers, universities and research institutes, clinicians, private providers, industry partners, patient advocacy organisations, philanthropists, and government around a common mission.

Their role will be to translate the latest scientific advances in cancer treatment into meaningful improvements in clinical care – ensuring discoveries do not remain confined to laboratories or overseas institutions but reach New Zealand patients as quickly as possible.

Concentrating cancer services creates powerful agglomeration benefits. Specialists working alongside researchers, surgeons, diagnostic services, clinical trial teams, and technology companies are better able to exchange knowledge, collaborate, and adopt new treatments. The Centre would also partner with universities to teach the next generation of oncologists.

The Centre would bring together capabilities including robotic and complex surgery, targeted treatments, cell and gene therapies, radiation oncology, molecular diagnostics and genomics, advanced imaging, intensive care, systemic therapy, and early-phase through Phase III clinical trials.

02 Keep the best. Attract the best.

Comprehensive cancer centres have become the gold standard for cancer care around the world. If New Zealand does not build institutions of the same calibre, we will not just be accepting inferior cancer care – we will make it harder to keep the people capable of delivering the best care.

The best oncologists, surgeons, researchers, and scientists want to work in places with world-class facilities, cutting-edge technology, major clinical trial programmes, and other leading specialists around them. If New Zealand cannot offer that environment, Australia and other countries will.

So the risk is a vicious cycle: inferior institutions make it harder to retain our best people, and losing our best people makes our cancer care worse still.

ACT will reverse that cycle by building an institution good enough to keep New Zealand's best and attract leading cancer specialists from around the world.

03 Unlocking private investment and innovation

The Centre will also make New Zealand a significantly more attractive destination for private cancer care, medical research, clinical trials, new therapies, and health technology investment.

International pharmaceutical and biotechnology companies increasingly choose where to conduct trials and launch new therapies based on the quality of local institutions, researchers, patient populations, and clinical infrastructure.

A comprehensive cancer centre operating at international scale would give New Zealand a stronger platform to compete for that activity.

That means more New Zealand patients gaining earlier access to innovative treatments, more research being conducted here, and more private investment flowing into our health and life-sciences sectors.

04 New Zealand can build it together

Government should not be the only source of ambition.

ACT will establish an independent philanthropic foundation from the beginning of the project and ensure the tax system rewards extraordinary generosity.

The foundation will have one overriding mission: to raise as much money as possible to make the National Cancer Centre bigger, better, and more capable. It would approach New Zealand's leading philanthropists, families, businesses, charitable trusts, community organisations, and successful Kiwis around the world.

Fundraising would begin immediately while the Centre is being scoped and designed. That means major gifts would not simply help pay for predetermined facilities, they could supercharge what gets built.

People who make extraordinary contributions will be recognised for them. Major donors would be able to secure naming rights for appropriate parts of the Centre. A transformational contribution could include naming rights to a hospital itself.

ACT will give the philanthropic foundation charitable donor status from the outset, ensuring donations to it are eligible for donation tax credits.

ACT will also remove the recently introduced $33,333 cap on the tax benefits available for charitable donations. This reform will apply to charitable giving generally, not just donations to the National Cancer Centre Foundation.

If New Zealanders want to give $1 million, $10 million, or more to cancer care, medical research, or other charitable causes, the tax system should encourage that generosity rather than impose an arbitrary ceiling on it.

For the National Cancer Centre, removing that ceiling will help unlock genuinely transformational philanthropy and allow New Zealanders' generosity to determine just how ambitious these institutions can become.

05 Funding world-class cancer care

The National Cancer Centre will be developed using a combination of public-private partnership financing, charitable donations, existing Crown health investment, and other private capital where appropriate.

Based on comparable international cancer centres and major New Zealand hospital projects, the indicative capital requirement is approximately $2 billion. The final cost will depend on the scope, design, financing structure, and facilities included in the two campuses.

This investment should be considered in the context of spending the Government will need to undertake regardless.

New Zealand already has more than $20 billion of planned health infrastructure investment extending beyond 2035. Existing cancer facilities will require replacement and upgrading over that period.

Cancer treatment costs are also expected to rise substantially as the population grows, ages, and new treatments become available. Current projections suggest New Zealand could be spending around an additional $1 billion a year on cancer care by 2035. Over the next 15 years, we expected to spend $50 billion on cancer treatments, and that's before we consider the funding for innovative new drugs.

The relevant question is therefore not whether government will spend more money on cancer. It is whether that money is used to perpetuate a dispersed system or to help create world-class institutions capable of delivering better outcomes.

Under ACT's model, the Crown would not necessarily own and finance every component of the Centre itself.

Instead, private capital could finance appropriate facilities through a public-private partnership, philanthropy could expand the scale and capability of the Centre, and Health New Zealand would become a major customer of the Centre.

Health New Zealand would locate its existing Auckland and Christchurch cancer services at the new campuses and purchase the clinical services and access to facilities required to treat publicly funded patients.

The Crown's ongoing financial liability would therefore principally arise through Health New Zealand purchasing cancer care and using the Centre's facilities. This expenditure, to a significant extent, would otherwise need to occur elsewhere in the health system. In the future, medical tourism from overseas could help subsidise the Centre's operations.

The exact Crown contribution and ongoing service costs will be determined through the business-case process and will depend on the final structure of the project.

What ACT will do

ACT will:

- Partner with the Department of Cancer Sciences at the University of Auckland and the Christchurch Cancer Foundation to complete detailed business cases for National Cancer Centre campuses in Auckland and Christchurch.
- Legislate to establish an independent, not-for-profit National Cancer Centre Foundation.
- Give the Foundation automatic charitable donee status so eligible donations receive the appropriate tax benefits.
- Develop the Centre using public-private partnerships, philanthropic capital, Crown health investment, and other private investment where appropriate.
- Direct Health New Zealand to locate its relevant Auckland and Christchurch cancer services at the new National Cancer Centre and contract with the Centre for the facilities and services required to treat publicly funded patients.
- Examine how health capital already earmarked for replacement and expansion of cancer infrastructure can be redirected into the Centre rather than duplicating investment elsewhere.

The result

ACT's National Cancer Centre will mean better cancer treatment and better survival rates for New Zealanders. It will concentrate expertise and create the scale required for genuinely world-class cancer care.

It will help keep New Zealand doctors, researchers, and scientists here while attracting outstanding international talent.

It will make New Zealand a more attractive destination for private healthcare investment, new technologies and therapies, medical research, and international clinical trials.

And it will combine government purchasing power, private capital, philanthropy, and national ambition to build something substantially better than government could deliver alone.

New Zealand can build one of the world's great cancer institutions. ACT will make it happen.